

Lecture 12

12.1 On the Final Exam

Good morning. I'll start by getting your third essays, then I'll give you back your second essays. I think we're still waiting for one student. So just before I get your essays, today will be the final class. I'll go over the final exam. And after today, no more assignments, no more top material — everything's finished. The only thing to worry about is the final exam.

So next week, attendance is optional if you want to come. I highly recommend it. But I will be checking attendance next week. Two good reasons to come, though: one is that we'll practice the final exam. I'll put up three practice questions, and if you come next week, please bring pen and paper with you. And I'll just give you one hour to practice as though it were the real final. Then, yeah, I won't have time to grade that for you. However, in week 15, attendance is optional Q&A, and if you want to come with that practice exam you wrote, I will give you a grade for that. I'll tell you how highly I would have scored it if that had been the real final exam.

You can also come in week 15 if you want to go over any of the essays — like if you want more feedback for your second, or your first, or your third essay, I'll be happy to try and give you that. And if you want to appeal a grade — right, if I said you didn't have an extended example or you didn't have enough evidence and you think you did — I'll be happy to hear your appeal. Don't come and say, "Please, please, please, I really want a higher grade." You must actually have a reason for that, but I'll be happy to entertain your appeals, or any other questions relating to the course.

So in week 15, you can show up; I'll be here. What I'll say is please come early, because if I come to class on week 15 and there's nobody here, I will probably wait five minutes and then go. So if you want to see me, come on time. If you come at break time, I might already be gone. And week 16 will be the same — if you want to see me, I might be here. You know, it's the day after Christmas, so if I am here I'm not going to be very awake, but, you know, probably I would say if you want to see me in week 16, let me know. If you want to see me, I'll show up in week 16. All right. The other reason to come next week, of course, is that I'll give you back your third essays next week. Let me get those from you.

So here are the instructions for the final exam. It's a handwritten one-hour exam. You've got two prompts, and try to write five paragraphs. The instructions say 400 words. I'm not counting your words, and my advice is to go for quality rather than quantity. So spend a bit of time thinking, mapping out what you're planning to write, and then try to write five paragraphs — roughly three to four sentences per paragraph, roughly 10 to 15 words per sentence. That will be fine. Like I say, I'm really not counting how many words you wrote exactly.

The exam paper will be two pages; you'll just write a two-page essay. So you'll have the front with the questions on the top here, and then below that there will be lines, and then on the second page this part is lined as well. But I would say write on all available sides: so write here, write here even though it's not lined, write here where it's lined, and write here where it's not lined, okay? So you can use all available space.

There should also be a third page attached to the back that you're meant to tear off, and that's just a piece of draft paper that you can use for planning, checking spellings, and things like that. But I don't collect that; that should be thrown away at the end of the exam. You've just got these three and a half sides to write on.

I think you're all familiar with doing handwritten exams in English, are you? Like you do it for the 高考, do you? If you haven't done it before, I think it's especially important to come next week and practice because—even for me, it's been a long time since I did anything like this, and I don't know how many pages I could write by hand in one hour. So figuring out how quickly you can think and how quickly you can write and how to manage your time is quite important. So, you know, you might think you can easily write two pages and then end up only writing one. I've seen lots of students do the practice exam before, and they only write four paragraphs — they don't get to the conclusion, for instance. So it's good to figure out your limitations and where you might have problems; then in the real final exam you can adjust for that and maybe spend more time planning or more time writing, depending on what you need.

Things like grammar and spelling — I am required to underline any error in the final. Like if you have a grammar mistake or a spelling mistake, I'm required to underline that. However, as long as I can understand what you're trying to say, that won't lose you points, okay? Unless it's really egregious — unless it goes really, really far, like everything is wrong — but otherwise it's not going to cost you marks. However, if I don't know what you're trying to say, then it becomes a problem — like if your grammar is so bad, if your spelling is so bad, and I don't even know what you're trying to say, I can't give you credit for that. 🙄

The same for handwriting. I'm not looking at your handwriting; there's no grade for, you know, beautiful handwriting. But if I can't understand your handwriting because it looks like chicken scratch, right, there is nothing I can do to help you, okay? I'll try my best, but I'm not going to sit there, you know, with a magnifying glass or something trying to work it out. So don't go crazy fast, because I think that might lead to poor handwriting. And also next week, I can, you know, give you advice that your handwriting is terrible — I can try to tell you to write a bit more clearly.

But like I say, don't worry too much if you spell a word slightly wrong — there are supposed to be two Ns and you only use one, for instance — that's really not going to hurt you. As I've said before though, you know, write words and sentences, like short sentences using common words. There's no extra credit for using big words, but you could lose credit if I don't understand what you're trying to say.

Also, the final exam counts for 40% of your final grade, so it's a big one. And if it were up to me and it was my decision, I would make the final exam worth like 20% and I would make the second essay worth like 20% as well, but this is fixed by the department; I cannot change it and I have no control over this.

If you've taken my speaking courses before, you know that the final exam is quite flexible. So in my speaking classes, if you don't make it in week 15 to give the final speech or the final debate, you can always come in week 16. And if you're really sick, you could come to my office in week 17 and give the speech. Okay, that is **not** true for this final. This is very rigid. There's no flexibility. There will be two Chinese teachers in the exam. They will count how many students are there. If there's a student missing, they will find your seat and write your name down, okay? I can't do anything about it then. I can't let you come to my office and give you a blank exam paper and let you do it later. You are marked as absent, your name's recorded, and you know, students often send me emails saying, "Oh, I missed my train, I went to 杭州 and I couldn't make it back." I can't help you there. I'm sorry — if you miss the exam, it's out of my hands. You have to go to the department and apply for the B exam.

So if you're planning to travel that weekend, or that kind of thing, you know, please make sure you get back on time. Last year, I had a student — all his grades were **A** for every assignment — and then he wasn't there in the final. He told me he missed his train from 杭州. He went for a graduate interview, and he said for some reason he missed his train. So please make sure you don't have problems like that, because he ended up with an **D-** final grade, right? If you take the reset, the highest grade I can give you in March is a **D-**. 🙄 Do your best to be there.

If you get sick or whatever, I don't know what to tell you — just try and let the department know as quickly as possible, because I think it is sometimes possible to get a deferred exam, right, like if you're genuinely ill and you have doctor's evidence and stuff like that. At least when you take the reset, you can do better than a D-.

Anyway, yeah, it's on Monday, December 29th at 3 p.m. in room 3208. I think all that information should be available to you on your e-hall or whatever system you guys use, so make a note. Again, I always get some student who shows up at 5 p.m., or shows up at 4 p.m., and "Oh my gosh, I slept in," or something. Just please, please, please make sure. And obviously, you know, try and be fresh. And I think the main factor probably is how good you feel on the day, you know, so make sure you're well rested.

You get two prompts. Yeah. Prompts aren't necessarily questions — they can be, but not always. Like a prompt could just be a statement, but I'll talk more about this after the break. So you pick one of them and write 400 words, five paragraphs, based on the prompt. One-hour time limit, and you cannot have phones, computers, or books or anything at the desk. Just bring pens with you, and everything else will have to be stored at the front of the classroom.

All right, so that's how the exam will operate. Yeah, final exam is 40%. Your three essays count for 30%. Your class performance counts for the other 30%. So that's the grading I've been doing in class: Did you read the essay? Did you contribute to the class discussion? That's how your grade is made up.

I get a lot of students asking me, you know, "Oh, my average score was 87, can I still get an A?" Yes, absolutely. With such a heavily weighted final exam, it's absolutely possible. If you get 95 for the final and you did decent contributions in the class discussions, it's absolutely possible to go up to an A from an A-. Of course it's also absolutely possible to go down to an A- or even a B from an A, so don't, like, don't drop the ball in the final exam either.

But I get a lot of students asking, "Should I PNP? I can't accept an A-, I will only accept an A. Will I get an A?" I can't promise you one way or the other. It just totally depends on how well it goes in the final exam. But if you're really nervous, then, you know, I don't want to be the one responsible for the A- that ruins your GPA, so in that case, do PNP. I had one student last term, and his average was like 89.3. And he asked me, "Can I get an A?" I said, "You can, but I don't know." In the end, he PNP'd. And actually, he came and asked me, "What was my average overall?" and it was actually 89.7 or something like that. So he just missed the A. And he was right to PNP. However, also last year, I had two students who PNP'd who would have got an A — like, they did get an A, but they PNP'd, which was very generous because they gave up their A's and two other students were able to take those A's instead of them. So what I'm saying is I can't really tell you one way or the other whether you should PNP. It has to be your own judgment.

All right, try to write five short paragraphs. It's up to you — you can do policy, value, or fact. Like, if you do policy, you know, "Fudan should do what," "Shanghai government should do what," "Chinese government should do what," "The American government should do what," like anything's fine. "We should ban something," "We should allow something" — all these things are fine.

If you do value, think of it as giving advice or saying something is good or bad. And if you do fact, it can be okay sometimes to argue fact — you know, something is true or false — so I don't mind that even though we didn't really cover it in the class; I don't mind some students doing that and it's okay. But sometimes I see it going wrong as well, so my advice if you do fact is: make a prediction. Say, "I predict that in the future something will happen, change."

If you are the kind of student who gets nervous in finals — whose, you know, brain doesn't work so quickly because you're under pressure and you're anxious — I think the best way to do it is think of a policy main idea and then give impact, values, and concession–rebuttal, right? This is what you've practiced before. You can mix it up; don't be so rigid. I'm not saying you *have* to do impact–values–concession–rebuttal. If you want to do concession–concession–impact or values–impact–impact, like, you can do it however you like. I'm not fussy.

So I'm marking it more openly than I did the first essay. But, like the first essay, I am looking to check, check, check, check, check — right — for every paragraph. Check twice or three times depending on what type of paragraph it is. If you check everything and there are no X's, you get an A. So it's as easy as that.

If you like to add other essay devices — use comparison, use framing, use extended examples, use further analysis — that's all fine. So totally up to you. Write as freely as you like in the final exam. So kind of think of it maybe as a blend of the first essay and the second essay, right? So it's a short essay, but you can use any device, and it doesn't have to be policy.

Anything counts as evidence. So all the stuff in the first essay and second essays — I'm saying, you know, statistics, quotes, and findings are what you should use, but common knowledge, principles, examples, and comparisons will also be counted as evidence in the final itself. When I say statistics, you know, you can kind of blend that with common knowledge. If I say China's population is 1.3 billion, America's population is around 350 million, right, so I'm not looking for necessarily exact data as long as the statistics are something that the average person knows. And that's fine.

I do sometimes get suspicious when students say things like, you know, very, very exact statistics — you know, "In World War I, 71,493,261 people were killed." Okay, that's a weird number to remember. So it's fine just to say, "70 million people died in the Second World War." I'm not looking for exact statistics like that when it comes to things like common knowledge — you know, "World War II ended in 1945," or "Donald Trump was the president." Right? Just any fact that we would all know. It's totally fine.

Indicate what you're doing in the exam with wording — that's important. I would say maybe the most important thing in the final is your wording. After the main idea is wording. So if you're giving framing, you might say "Before arguing..." Right? If you're giving a comparison, you would say "Compared to..." If you're giving an example, you would say "For example..." and so on. Okay, so all that wording that we've covered in the class before — try to use it, and think. It also forces you to do it. So you might say, for evidence, "As we all know," right, "For example...", "The principle of...", "Research has shown..." — something like that — to indicate wording.

A friend of mine at Fudan — he's retired now — but he used to teach English literature. And one of the questions in his final exam was a poetry question. And the students had to analyze a poem that they'd learned in the class. And there was like a box for them to write in. And he said sometimes the students would leave the box empty — they couldn't remember the poem, and they wouldn't write anything. And he would always say, "Just write something, even if it's total nonsense. 🐼" Because I cannot pretend you gave an answer if the box is empty, right? I can't give the exam paper to my boss and say, "Here's the student who got an A," and there's nothing in that box. They will say, "Why is the box empty? How did they get credit for that answer? They didn't write anything."

Kind of the same principle here. Even if your evidence isn't very good, even if your claim isn't very clear, say "This policy would..." right? Now I can say, "Oh, look, they gave an impact claim," right? "Statistics show—" and I say, "Okay, they gave evidence." And it also forces you to try to do it. So please make sure you're using appropriate wording. And then I can pretend that you did it and you can pretend that you wrote it. So help me to help you is what I was saying. But if you just write a word salad... yeah. I don't know what's what. It's very difficult for me to give you credit for that. Okay, so even if you're writing a word salad, put wording into the

word salad. You know: "As we all know," or, "The government should do this," "As we all know, this shows that..." Right? For analysis, you might say, "This shows us what..." And I can pretend you did it.

Examples are fine. Like I said, don't use examples in the first, second, and third essays as evidence—use them to *demonstrate* something. But in the final exam you can say, "For example, in one case in Shanghai last year, this thing happened. From this we can see..., this shows us what..." That's totally fine. Examples are great, and you can also give extended examples. All right? So if you want to give a whole paragraph where you just tell a little story, that's totally fine.

You know, sometimes—I think it was last year—there was some story every student gave as an example. There was some "fat cat (胖猫)" online thing. Do you guys remember this? Something about a cat, something that had happened in the Chinese media, and I hadn't heard about it. Like—yeah, it was like "fat cat." Was it like some guy who was cheating girls on dating apps or something like that? I can't remember. But I think about half the students—half the students—gave this example: "As we saw in a recent case in China, there was the Fat Cat scandal where blah blah blah..." And I was asking people, "What the hell was the Fat Cat scandal? I've never heard of it." But so what I'm saying is: sometimes the topics in the exam relate to a recent event, and lots of students will give the example. That's fine. That's great. You know, I'll give you full credit for using a relevant extended example. So please don't feel confined to only using impact, values, and concession. If you can think of a good example, give it. If you can think of good framing or comparison, do that.

So yeah, use wording. Evidence can be anything that we normally don't allow, and then just explain it—explain your logic—and then you'll be fine. Any questions about the final? After the break, I will show you some previous exam papers, and we'll practice making main ideas based on those.

Before the break, I'd just like you guys to practice making a paragraph. So this should be the first sentence of your paragraph: either this, this, this, or this. And then I want you guys to fill in the evidence and the analysis.

- Compared to a recession, wealth inequality is worse.
- AI development is slowing and will not advance so rapidly in the future.
- Allowing athletes to use performance-enhancing drugs would make sport more enjoyable to watch.
- Patriotism is among the highest virtues; schools should promote the highest virtues.

So this one is a comparison: "Compared to a recession, wealth inequality is worse," so you can pick that if you want to. "AI development is slowing and will not advance so rapidly in the future"—so that's a fact claim; if you are making a prediction, you need to say something like that. "Allowing athletes to use performance-enhancing drugs would make sport more enjoyable to watch"—you know, performance-enhancing drugs, you know, those injections that give you big muscle, right? "Patriotism is among the highest virtues; schools should promote the highest virtues"—so that's a values claim. So impact, values, fact, comparison.

So pick one of these, make it your first sentence, and then try to complete the whole paragraph. Add the evidence, add the analysis, and I'll let you spend 10 minutes. I know I didn't ask you to bring pen or paper with you today, so it's fine if you want to type it, that's no problem. Just remember you can obviously type much faster than you can write by hand. Go ahead and try and do that now, and you've got 10 minutes. Complete the paragraph.

(TEN MINUTES LATER...)

Yong:

AI development is slowing and will not advance so rapidly in future. We all know that GPT-4, which is ten times larger than GPT-3, was a massive success. Many of us believed GPT-5, which is ten times larger than GPT-4, would deliver true Artificial General Intelligence (AGI). Yet it turned out to be only an

incremental improvement. It was like expecting a spaceship and getting a slightly faster Tesla instead. And Ilya Sutskever, the co-founder of OpenAI, has warned that scaling Large Language Models (LLMs) is reaching a plateau, and that we are running out of high-quality human text on the internet to feed these models. So LLMs are likely just an early result in the pursuit of human-level AI, and possibly even a dead end.

Okay, that is 10 minutes. So if you didn't finish writing, see this as a warning: write faster in the real final, because yeah, you've got maybe 10 minutes to plan, and then 10 minutes per paragraph after that. So group up wherever you're sitting nearby and share your paragraph with the others. Do you see evidence? Is the analysis clear? And if you would like me to take a look, just raise your hand, I'll be happy to come and tell you what I think of your paragraph.

(FIVE MINUTES LATER...)

All right guys, after the break we'll look at some real essays. And like I said last week, please don't post pictures of them on 小红书... you might get me in trouble 🙈, which did happen recently. So keep these confidential, please. I don't mind taking pictures; just don't share them with anyone, and definitely don't put them up on the internet. It's possible... I don't know why. I mean, I don't see any reason why. Is it normal in China to show previous papers before exams? In the UK, it's super normal. They will publish the previous year's exam. Like, when I was a high school student, we would always look at the previous year's exams for practice. So for me it's like a totally normal thing. But a few weeks ago, my course leader went really angry in our group saying, "Who put this online? Oh my God!" It was my class. So I don't know why that's a problem for them. 🙈

Just one other thing I didn't mention: it didn't happen last year, but it has happened before. Sometimes there are students who are over 90 but not in the top 30% of the class, and then in that case you will get dragged down to an A-. I haven't calculated the average grades yet. However, I feel like they are higher than usual. Obviously AI is helping students a lot with the class essays, and so I'm not seeing that many low scores anymore. So, yeah, I do feel for that reason there is some chance that students—even if you get like 90.03 or something like that—you could end up with an 89.9 instead. So just be aware. All right, take a break.

12.2 Previous Finals

So remember that this exam is designed for every student who takes this course—like a thousand students or so. And different teachers have different requirements and teach different things. I will mark your final exams, so do what I say. Only I look at your finals, and then they're given to the department. But even then, I'm pretty sure nobody checks them—they just check the grades; they don't check anything else. So unless you appeal—if you say your grade isn't fair, I guess they would pull it out—but otherwise it's just me. So do what I say.

And the important thing here is: do **not** simply answer the prompt "yes or no," "agree or disagree." There are two types of prompts. Some are open-ended, which is fine. Obviously with those ones, do try to answer it—give a policy or value or fact based on the question. But other prompts are kind of like a statement or a yes-or-no question or agree-or-disagree. Do **not** say, "I agree" or "I disagree." Instead, see the prompt as suggesting a topic, and then make a main idea—a policy, value, or fact—on that topic.

So the topic can be wide, okay? If the topic given is technology, you could write about AI, you could write about robotics, you could write about synthetic biology, or whatever. But if you write an essay about food or animals or something, I will think, okay, that's off the topic. But as long as you're within that topic area, that's totally fine. So don't feel constrained by the prompt. Write any main idea based on the topic.

Analyze it. Maybe you'd spend five minutes thinking about your main idea and another five minutes planning. My advice is to make an outline. So write down your main idea: "China should tax X ." Impact, example, comparison, final significance. And I think that will help you avoid making mistakes. I often see exam papers where the student starts writing the intro, and then they scribble it out and start again. You've wasted a lot of time doing that. You've made your exam paper look messy.

If you make an outline—think for five minutes—firstly, making an outline forces you to think, right? Just like a wording forces you to do that thing. But it helps you avoid making mistakes. And like I said, you'll have that extra piece of paper, so you can write down your outline on that extra piece of paper. **Five minutes thinking of a main idea, five minutes outlining, and then ten minutes per paragraph.** I'm just saying that's a standard way of doing it. Maybe you're really fast at writing and so you could spend a bit more time planning. Maybe you're very slow writing and you have to spend a bit more time writing—that's fine. But like I say, next week you can kind of see what problems you might have with time management.

Here are some examples. This is an old, old, old one. I had nothing to do with this; this was before I came here. I got it from colleagues. And like I said, back then they gave you 75 minutes—they used to get 15 minutes more than you guys get.

Anyway, this is what the exam paper will look like roughly. So obviously write in your name, student number, major. You don't have to put your English name, but I can identify you by your student number. I think it helps me if you put your English name, because then I can find you quite quickly rather than typing in every student number. Also, if I have two identifiers—sometimes the student writing is so bad I can't tell if that's a zero or a six. And there have been times when I literally couldn't find the student. I had to wait until I marked all the others and then find the student by process of elimination. Luckily, if there had been two students, I would have been in more trouble, but there was only one. But if you write your English name, your Chinese name, and your student number, I'm going to find you.

- **(2014 春 Prompt A)** If you provide all-purpose technology that can be used for learning and entertainment, children choose entertainment. Technology by itself doesn't undo itself. It amplifies it.

The important thing is the prompt. And sorry about these—I can't believe these were given as final exams by the English Department of Fudan. 🙄 It's terrible that they have bad English. Like I said, this was nothing to do with me. But like, "It amplifies it"—that is not a sentence. 🙄 That is not a full English sentence. It's crazy. "If you provide all-purpose technology that can be used for learning and entertainment, children choose entertainment. Technology by itself doesn't undo itself—I don't know what that means. 🙄 It amplifies it—I don't know what that means. 🙄" Anyway. But here you've got "technology, learning, entertainment, children"—you really have four nouns there, and I would not expect students to combine all four. Just generally write about this topic: learning and technology, or entertainment and technology. That would be fine.

So if I say "learning and technology," does anything come to mind? Now, there was once a question—if you've read the handbook, in Part 4 of the handbook I give this example—the question was: *TikTok, a Chinese app, now has 200 million users worldwide. What do you think of this phenomenon?* And 40 students wrote, "I think it is good," and another 40 students wrote, "I think it is bad." And my brain was melting after marking that exam. Everybody said roughly the same thing: *My little cousin lies on the sofa watching TikTok videos. I think he's wasting his time.*

So if there is something that seems like a very obvious answer, maybe think a bit more deeply. Because I would still like it if you could stand out a bit instead of giving the generic answer. Now here, the generic answer is probably AI, right? If you said, *All school kids should have a personalized AI teacher*, for instance, I think a lot of students would probably think of that. So can you think about anything else? Technology and learning?

Or banning smartphones from the classroom seems like an obvious answer to give, doesn't it? Obviously back in 2014, that would not have been the answer—no AI back then—but now there would definitely be an AI answer. So can you think of anything else? Technology, education, learning. Why not say something like *gamify education*? We should gamify education; math class should be based on games. We should have games on phones to teach kids math or something like that. Teachers should use games in the classroom for teaching subjects like mathematics or physics. I'm not saying it's a great idea, but it's original; it's definitely good enough for the point. Anyone else think of others?

Absolutely fine to argue against a policy if you want to—just make it clear in the introduction. You might even give a bit of framing if you do that. For example: *Recently China has introduced this policy to prevent addiction. Let me describe the policy first; now let me argue against it.*

- **(2014 春 Prompt B)** Do the benefits of science and technology come at the cost of undesirable changes to people's lives?

Do the benefits of science and technology come at the cost of undesirable changes to people's lives? I mean, the department seems to really like technology topics in the final. But again, AI seems like the obvious answer here, right? *AI is stopping us from thinking*—that could be a bit of a value/fact type topic there. Any other examples, though—negative technology? Has technology affected your life other than AI? I guess you could argue certain jobs are at risk of being replaced by technology. You could talk about that.

As a teacher, I think my life has definitely been negatively affected by technology. Ten years ago, students would all read the whole essay and come to class with strong opinions on the essay. Today, nobody reads the essays anymore, and when I read the assignments, 90%—or 70%—are written by artificial intelligence now. So my job has become less interesting thanks to technology. You could talk about it in that context. And certain jobs—I'm sure many truck drivers and taxi drivers are very worried just now that they are going to be replaced by Waymo or one of the Chinese companies doing it—there are many companies which are just about to release, or have even released, self-driving taxis.

- **(Prompt A)** As long as our actions do no harm to others, people should be free to act however they want. Is this a practical guide to policy?

Now, usually you can tell if I wrote the exam question because it's very open-ended—it could apply to different topics, which is good; that means you have more choice. So this one is written by me: *As long as our actions do no harm to others, people should be free to act however they want. Is this a practical guide to policy?*

Now, of course, for the other teacher's class, the students say, "Yes, it is a practical guide to policy," or "No, it is not a practical guide to policy." You guys should just take this as a topic suggestion and think of a policy, value, or fact—main idea—based on that. What topics come to mind with this?

Drugs—absolutely. Why can I not take drugs if I'm only hurting myself? Gambling—right? If I want to gamble for money, why should I be stopped? Alcohol, smoking, surrogacy—you know, surrogacy, 代孕, having a child for someone else. There are many topics within that area. So that's what was being suggested there. If a student argued *China should legalize surrogacy*, that's fine.

- **(Prompt B)** Today day, there exists a very strange phenomenon in China. Both rich families and poor families in China would go to great lengths to indulge children in delights of leisure and material comforts. Write a composition to make your critical analysis of the social phenomenon.

Again, bad English here: *Today day, there exists a very strange phenomenon in China. Both rich families and poor families in China would go to great lengths to indulge children in delights of leisure and material comforts. Write a composition to make your critical analysis of the social phenomenon.*

All right, so I think there's kind of a narrow topic suggested here—the 小皇帝 thing, like the little emperor. That's what that's describing, isn't it? If you give your kids everything they want and they're the only child, they become the 熊孩子. It's not something people talk about so much nowadays, is it? I think this one was before the pandemic.

But yeah, so in a narrow sense, you could talk about spoiling kids in a value sense. But my advice would be to talk about it in a more broad, general sense. So *parenting* is the topic raised here.

So, you know: *Parents should force their children to play outside every day. Parents should not interfere in their children's schoolwork. Parents should hit their kids. Parents should not hit their kids. China should ban parents from hitting their kids.* There are lots of ways you could go here.

Any other parenting topics that you can think of? As children of parents yourselves, you should obviously have some ideas and thoughts. And obviously be able to give examples with evidence—for example, *My friend's parents would always do this, and I think this harmed her, or this was good for her.*

So my point is: try and see these in general, broad terms, not the narrow thing it's talking about. It's talking about the little emperor—try and think of it as *parenting*.

- **(Prompt A)** Is popular culture the strongest influence on a young person's identity?

Is popular culture the strongest influence on a young person's identity? Pop culture, young people's identity—what comes to your mind? Here's my chain of thinking. What comes to my mind first is Disney. So many kids, especially young girls, want to dress up on Halloween as Elsa from *Frozen* and sing *Let It Go*. And when I used to—before the 双减 policy—teach over at Fudan Fuzhong, teenagers, something that always surprised me was how much these teenagers in China love Disney from America. They would always be talking about it and singing songs from it and stuff like that.

I used to think American culture has a big impact on urban Chinese youth, right? And I used to wonder what China could do for its soft power in the future—what will China do to influence young people in other countries toward Chinese culture? You know, every country has this. I think a lot of young people in Southeast Asia love British football, right? Very popular in Malaysia, Indonesia—Manchester United, Arsenal, and stuff like this. So Britain has its soft power: football, and children's books like *Harry Potter*. You know, that's another one you could think of here.

I remember teaching here at Fudan I would have students wearing Hogwarts uniforms—and especially English majors—and they'd talk with a very proper British accent like this, sounding more British than I do. And I think, wow, this British culture is very powerful, from *Harry Potter*, for instance.

Or, you know, what would China's be? Do you think—some people say food. I always say, well, it's already food; it's there now. Chinese food is already super popular. Even if you go to a village in Britain, you'll probably find a Chinese restaurant in a small town.

Or could it be video games? Could it be movies? Could it be—you know, Japan has comic books—could it be something like that? Anyway, a topic like that, I think, would be very interesting here. You know: *China should promote X for its soft power abroad.* I think most people would say video games, wouldn't you? Korea has already dominated music and TV drama; what can China do? China has had some success already with the 悟空 thing, isn't it?

- **(Prompt B)** On technicalization of education.

On technicalization of education—"technicalization" is not a word. 🙄 This is shocking to me that they would put that in an English exam, but they did. But you can guess, like the previous question, it's about technology in education.

- **(Prompt A)** *Fo xi*, which means "Buddha style", is a buzzword for young people's approach to work and life. What's your view on this life philosophy?

Fo xi, Buddha style, a buzzword. For young people's approach to work and life, what's your view on this life philosophy? Again, I was quite annoyed by this because I had never heard of *fo xi* (佛系), so when my students wrote about it, I didn't know what they were talking about, and I had to ask people, "What is *fo xi*?"

I think *fo xi* became *tang ping* (躺平), and that became *bai lan* (摆烂), right? It's kind of the same thing. No? Okay—talking about *bai lan* is negative, this is more positive. Yeah, I see. But obviously this one—if you look at it in a narrow sense—it's talking about *fo xi*. If you look at it in a broad sense, it is talking about *life philosophy*.

Can you think of any other life philosophies that you could recommend to people? Can you think of any other life philosophies? Say it again—*scientism* (科学至上主义), so that means believing in science? Oh you mean *cynicism* (犬儒主义), right? Like *Diogenes*, the philosopher? So it's a bit like this: you give up all your belongings.

So there is a famous story about Diogenes—if you give this example when you write the essay. You know, Alexander the Great, the Greek who conquered the Middle East and India and Afghanistan—anyway, the great conqueror, the greatest conqueror in the world before Hitler, I suppose. But, you know, the story goes: Alexander the Great wanted to meet Diogenes when he went to the city, and Diogenes lived in a barrel, right? Because he didn't believe in owning stuff. And when Alexander leaned over the barrel and said, "I will give you anything you want. What do you want?" and Diogenes said, "I want you to get out of my sunlight." So, give up your worldly possessions and live a life of *minimalism* (极简主义). 😊 You might say "No." And I think there's a Japanese book that was very popular about this—like getting rid of all your stuff. Can you think of any other life philosophies?

Say it again? Yeah, the *Übermensch* (超人哲学). Okay—although that has quite, you know, kind of negative connotations nowadays, because it was often used by Hitler to justify his domination. Yeah, but that's a prejudice because Hitler didn't really get Nietzsche's idea. And Hitler got a lot of things wrong with Darwinism as well. Nietzsche argued that we have the right to define our own values. We have the right to say what's more important to us, to put our own role, and there is something that needs to be overcome. And then the Nazis used it to mean there was one group of people who were superior and they should dominate the earth, right?

Are there any other popular life philosophies nowadays? Someone in the last class said *living in the moment*, you know, living in the WeChat moment, right? Just exist for today, not caring too much about the future.

- **(Prompt A)** When punishing criminals, the common punishment is either a prison sentence, a fine, or the death penalty for serious crimes. Recently, a significant number of financial criminals in China were banned from using payment apps such as Alipay and WeChat as punishment. What other types of non-traditional punishments could we adopt?

And the last one here—this one's actually quite good. This one says: *What types of non-traditional punishment could we adopt?* You know, so if you said murderers should be sent to 新疆 to plant trees for the rest of their life, right? Or *China should bring back caning*—you know, if you commit a serious crime, you should be beaten as punishment like in Singapore or something.

- **(Prompt B)** Many people argue we are overpaying some professions and underpaying others. Which profession is overpaid or underpaid?

So of course, if you want to get an A, the correct answer for this is English teachers, right? English teachers are underpaid 🙄—that's the correct answer. Just joking—anything is fine. But let's practise this one.

- **(Prompt A)** How far should we create policy to address inequality within society?

- **(Prompt B)** some people argue advertising has a negative impact on consumption and purchasing. To what extent do you agree with this statement?

So I'll give you five minutes to discuss it in a group. Don't really discuss in a group in the real final exam—please try to think on your own. Just try and come up with an idea for each one.

So, *how far should we create policy to address inequality within society?* I won't give you any clues—just think about it. And *some people argue advertising has a negative impact on consumption and purchasing. To what extent do you agree with this statement?* Okay, so try and make a **policy, value, or fact** idea for each one of these two. Discuss with each other.

(FIVE MINUTES LATER...)

Okay, then let's hear some main ideas—two from each group.

Louis: Elite universities do more harm—like we should cancel the DEI policy.

Good, good. Yeah, I definitely think if you've taken debate with me, you've got a bit of an advantage here, because that's something we focus on quite a lot. Yep, so *elite universities do more harm than good*—I think that would be fine. I do worry maybe a little bit that you're giving yourself a challenge there with a comparative structure, but that's great. You can do it well. You know, elite versus non-elite universities and what's the difference—but yeah, that's great. I mean, better to take a challenge than to make it too easy for yourself. Great.

How about the second one? Could you think of a main idea based on advertising and spending? I do think both of these maybe are about policy, right? That one as well seems to be—you know—should we have some policies about advertising, for example, that you guys didn't think about? Such as video platforms shouldn't force people to watch ads. Actually, you know, I've heard that maybe three or four times already this week. That seems to be quite a popular one—the short-video apps, like 抖音, shouldn't force people to watch advertisements between videos.

Yong: We should address the problem of inequality by wealth redistribution.

Well, I would say that's maybe too vague. 🙄 You might want to say *how*. So we should tax—again, going back to the debate classic—there should be no billionaires. No one should be allowed to be a billionaire, right? Once your wealth reaches 999 million dollars, that's the cutoff, and you cannot earn more money. There should be no dollar billionaires in the world—something specific like that. So don't just say—we talked about this before—make it clear. Don't say "we should fix this problem." Say *this* would fix *this* problem, like a specific policy. As long as it's kind of a specific policy, that's fine. You kind of want to give a powerful framing—that would be great, but it's not required as long as the policy is clear.

Did you think of a topic for the second prompt—for advertising? I heard a good one on Wednesday when students said only small companies should be allowed to advertise; companies like Coca-Cola and McDonald's should be banned from advertising. Only companies below a certain size should be allowed to advertise. I thought that was very good—very original.

Any others? You guys think of anything about advertising?

HY: I think AI should be banned in advertising.

Yeah—good, interesting. I would actually say that's quite good, because, you know, the topic here doesn't bring up AI, but to apply it would be quite interesting. Good—so we shouldn't have AI commercials on television or the internet. I guess maybe you would need a bit of framing to say how this is becoming common.

Okay, fine. So mostly these are okay—you know, these are fine. Just be careful: when you get to *young*, be more specific. And if you think about this one—*inequality*—you could think of gender, race, region, you know, religion (not in China, but in some countries religious inequality), disability, age, right? There are all kinds of ways you could go with that. Don't feel too constrained, right?

You know, the first thing I think of here is quotas—minimum numbers, right? So Fudan should require that 30% of STEM students be female. Or Fudan should require that 30% of foreign language majors be male. Like a quota. Or the government should require that 40% of leading government members be female. Anyway, I think that's fine.

So don't forget: next week, bring with you pen and paper. I'll just give you back your third essays. By the way, the third essays—I'm still marking the second essays for this afternoon's class, so the third essays will be marked very quickly. That will give you too much feedback on that, so if you want feedback, come in Week 15.

Just show up on time; I'll give you back your third essays. I'll put up three prompts like these on the screen, and then I'll give you one hour to practice as though it were a real final exam. And yeah, the remaining part of the class, I'll just get you guys to look over each other's practice exams. And like I said, if you want me to look at them, bring them to me in Week 15 and I'll be happy to give you feedback, okay?

So that is it. We are done. 😊 The course is over, and you do not need to show up again if you don't want to—but I do recommend it next week. I think it's quite useful to practice. Any questions about the final?

All right, good luck. Will I see any of you again next term? Next term I'm only teaching public speaking. So if you want a real challenge, that might be the course for you. I know some of you have taken this course already. All right, you're free to go. See you next week.

(APPLAUSE)

12.3 Practice Exam

(A WEEK LATER...)

Good morning. We will start in a couple of minutes, just wait for some students. And don't forget all the details about the finals, make sure you are there in the right place on time. Next week I'll be here. So you want to show up and ask any questions about the course, the three essays or your class performance score, and you can bring the final exam we practice today. Some students will even write more practice finals at home by themselves, and bring them to Q&A class. So anything like that is fine.

I'll be here in week 16 as well. Don't forget if you're not here on time and I was sitting here alone in the classroom, I will go. So if you want to see me, come on time. So any question about the final before we start?

Steven: I forget to bring a piece of paper 😞

Yeah—you can have a Public Speaking grading form and write on the back. 😊 Anyone else need a piece of paper?

Alright. I will give you three prompts, one policy, one value and one fact. And like I said last week—well, to be honest, all these prompts are written by me, so they are open-ended prompts. In the real final exam, only one of the prompts is written by me, the other one is written by a Chinese teacher. So if you pick that prompt, don't just agree or disagree with it. 🤖 Analyse it and create a main idea. If you pick mine in the real final, it will be like—I don't mean it will be the same topic—but it will be like these prompts. So you must create your independent main idea.

I strongly recommend making a brief outline. You guys are my fourth writing class this week. Based on what I have seen already, some students are really slow at writing. They make an outline and only write half an essay somehow. And some students are really fast, they can make a full outline and six sentences per paragraph. So there is a huge difference in how much you can actually write by hand. But I absolutely keep saying to the students who bring me their practice exam—something I keep saying is that *plan every point*, because I keep seeing lots of students giving circular logic, "Students should learn this skill because students lack this skill," but what is the reason for learning that skill? 🤔 So do try to make an outline, and you will find it helpful for you to write more clearly and efficiently.

- ① When should policy be used to restrict technology?
- ② What skill should young people try to develop?
- ③ What will Fudan look like 20 years from now?

So if there is no question, we will start. You have one hour—oh yeah, we will go through the break and everything, so if you need to go out or come in, just go ahead, don't ask me for permission or something like that. Okay, time starts now. 🕒

(ONE HOUR LATER...)

Okay, guys, that's one hour. Pens down. And if you didn't finish writing, take it as a warning to manage your time better in the real final exam. Feel free to leave any time, you don't have to stay, but if you would like something to do, then group up, three or four together, and look at each other's final exams. Could you identify the different components of the essay? One student showed me her essay and she didn't use wording for framing, she didn't say "Before arguing..." So it looks like a bad claim. 🤔 Things like that are very important. Try to use wording. To help me is to help yourself. And if you want me to look at your essay, just bring it up, I will be here. 😊

Title: We Should Regulate AI to Be More Profitable In the Short Term

According to Bain's sixth technological report, AI companies should make \$3 trillion in revenue ^{In this hype, by 2030} merely to pay the cost of computing resources required. AI is imagined to be the greatest money-making machine in human history. It is the biggest bubble since the dot-com crash. The lesson is learned: We should use ^{technological} regulations to reduce the bubble during technological hype.

~~A bubble happens occurs when the price of something goes grows very fast due to enthusiasm and fear of missing out, with little or no relationship to its fundamentals.~~ Technological bubbles can deal a heavy blow to both the economy and the development of technology. The most infamous example is the dot-com bubble during late 1990s. At that time, investors treated ~~new~~ website traffic as gold and poured money into internet companies whose business models were untested and immature. If the government used regulations ~~to~~ against the over-valuation of internet companies, a lot of damage ~~could~~ ^{could} be avoided. ^{unqualified}

Capital and market should be regulated. John Maynard Keynes viewed ~~the role of~~ government ~~control~~ as an important role in regulating the market. That was what American government did during the Depression — massive government borrowing and monetary expansion. ^{Great} But before the Great Depression struck at 1929, the American government believed that the market ~~can~~ ^{could} regulate itself, and that the best thing to do was to do nothing. They failed to solve the problem when the economy was growing alarmingly fast. Capital and market are blind. As Marx put it, as long as the profit is suitable, they do not ^{mind} murdering themselves. That is why we should regulate the technological hype by government control.

My opponents might argue that ^{more} regulation means lower speed in AI development, thereby making us lose the AI arm race. Yet healthier growth is equally important. A major red flag in the current AI hype is that most ^{AI} technological companies are not making profit. Considering the huge debt on them, the most important thing we should do is to find outlets in the secondary market to make AI more profitable.

After the Dot-com crash, ~~companies~~ collapsed, and on their ashes, giants like Google and Amazon
risen. If we maintain a healthier growth by market regulation,
more of our forces will survive in the up-coming crash. That ^{will} actually
~~helps us with~~ give us an edge in the long run.

So what can we do to ~~regulate the~~ work against the looming AI bubble?

Okay, Yong... So I can infer your claim, do you know what I mean? I can understand your claim after I have read your second paragraph, which is good... But in the final exam, it is probably safer to put the claim as the first sentence. Because sometimes when I see a paragraph like this, I can't extract a claim immediately. It's clear after reading the whole paragraph, but it's better to make the claim the first sentence of the paragraph... Perfect, do that in the final exam.

Yong: Thank you, sir.

You're welcome.

(BEFORE THE END OF THE CLASS...)

Yong: Sir, may I ask you why you underlined this word?

(pointing to the underlined "world government" in Yong's third essay)

It's not a mistake with the language. I just feel like it's quite an interesting claim. Why would that happen because is that what people are talking about or thinking of doing... It seems unreasonable. Like in the west, it's quite a negative thing. You know, people may associate this kind of thing with anti-Jewish conspiracy or other crazy kind of stuff. It is negatively connotated in English, a "world government." If you say that to an average western person, they will say "oh, you evil bastard," right? So do be careful.

Yong: Thank you, sir.

Welcome.

The End